

Finding silver linings in a year of turmoil

The three titles for the host at the Syed Modi India International Super 300 were **cathartic** in a year where Indian badminton had too many lows and sparingly few highs.

Uthra Ganesan

uthra.ganesan@thehindu.co.in

When Lakshya Sen finally hit the shuttle into the crowd on Sunday night after his most comprehensive win of the week to claim the Syed Modi India International Super 300, it was not just him celebrating a title win. **Given the challenges Indian badminton faced throughout the year, it was a cathartic moment for fans of the sport, reigniting hope for a more promising future in the coming year.**

Before Lakshya, the centre court at the Babu Banarasi Das UP Badminton Academy had already witnessed three Indians being crowned champions in a competition that has been a happy hunting ground for the home favourites.

While PV Sindhu expectedly claimed her third title in the city to join compatriot Saina Nehwal as the only three-time winners, the pair of Treasa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand wrote itself into the history books as the first Indian women's duo to win the title since the tournament's inception in 2009. But Lakshya's win was the most dominating.

It was a fitting end to a week — and the year for the two top-seeded singles stars — that began on a less-than-promising note. Even before action could get underway in the City of Nawabs, India's continued struggles in the sport widely considered as the second most popular after cricket had suffered yet another setback. The top-seeded men's pair, Satwiksairaj

Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty (Sat-Chi), withdrew from the competition citing injury concerns and a focus on rehabilitation ahead of the next season. The tournament, which once featured legends like Tommy Sugiarto, Viktor Axelsen, and Taufik Hidayat at their peak, as well as champions like Carolina Marin and

